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The Benedictus

(Canticle of Zechariah)

The Benedictus is also known as the Canticle or Song of Zechariah. It is the prayer that Zechariah recited following the birth of John the Baptist.

It celebrates God's faithfulness and the fulfilment of His promises, while looking toward John the Baptist, who will prepare the way for the Messiah.

Traditionally, the Benedictus is prayed as part of Lauds (Morning Prayer) in the Liturgy of the Hours.

ENGLISH

Blessed be the Lord, the God of Israel,
he has come to his people and set them free.
He has raised up for us a mighty saviour,
born of the house of his servant David,
through his holy prophets he promised of old
that he would save us from our enemies,
from the hands of all who hate us.
He promised to show mercy to our fathers
and to remember his holy covenant.
This was the oath he swore to our father Abraham,
to set us free from the hands of our enemies,
free to worship him without fear,
holy and righteous in his sight all the days of our life.

LATIN

Benedictus Dominus Deus Israel,
quia visitavit et fecit redemptionem plebis suae,
et erexit cornu salutis nobis
in domo David pueri sui,
sicut locutus est per os sanctorum,
qui a saeculo sunt, prophetarum eius,
salutem ex inimicis nostris,
et de manu omnium qui oderunt nos;
ad faciendam misericordiam cum patribus nostris,

et memorari testamenti sui sancti,
iusiurandum quod iuravit ad Abraham patrem nostrum,
datum se nobis,
ut sine timore, de manu inimicorum nostrorum liberati,
serviamus illi
in sanctitate et iustitia coram ipso,
omnibus diebus nostris.

ENGLISH

You, my child, shall be called the prophet of the Most High;
for you will go before the Lord to prepare his way,
to give his people knowledge of salvation
by the forgiveness of their sins,
in the tender compassion of our God
the dawn from on high shall break upon us,
to shine on those who dwell in darkness and the shadow of death,
and to guide our feet into the way of peace.

Glory to the Father and to the Son and to the Holy Spirit.
As it was in the beginning, is now, and will be forever.
Amen.

LATIN

Et tu, puer, propheta Altissimi vocaberis;
praeibis enim ante faciem Domini parare vias eius,
ad dandam scientiam salutis plebi eius
in remissionem peccatorum eorum,
per viscera misericordiae Dei nostri,
in quibus visitabit nos oriens ex alto,
illuminare his qui in tenebris et in umbra mortis sedent,
ad dirigendos pedes nostros in viam pacis.

Gloria Patri, et Filio, et Spiritui Sancto.
Sicut erat in principio, et nunc, et semper,
et in saecula saeculorum.
Amen.

Scripture

Luke 1:68-79

"Blessed be the Lord God of Israel, for he has visited and redeemed his people, and has raised up a horn of salvation for us in the house of his servant David, as he spoke by the mouth of his holy prophets for of old, that we should be saved from our enemies, and from the hand of all who hate us; to perform the mercy promised to our fathers, and to remember his holy covenant, the oath which he swore to our father Abraham, to grant us that we, being delivered from the hand of our enemies, might serve him without fear, in holiness and righteousness before him all the days of our life.

And you, child, will be called prophet of the Most High; for you will go before the Lord to prepare his ways, to give knowledge of salvation to his people in the forgiveness of their sins, through the tender mercy of our God, when the day shall dawn upon us from on high to give light to those who sit in darkness and in the shadow of death, to guide our feet into the way of peace."

Reflection

A Song at Dawn

The Benedictus is the song of a man who has waited.

Zechariah had known silence. He had known uncertainty. He had known the long years in which God's promises seemed distant and the hopes of Israel seemed to remain unanswered.

And then God acted.

A child was born.

The silence was broken.

And Zechariah's first great words were not words about himself.

They were words of praise.

Blessed be the Lord, the God of Israel.

The Benedictus begins by looking upward. Before Zechariah speaks about his son, his people, their enemies, or the future, he speaks about God.

God has visited His people.

God has remembered His covenant.

God has raised up salvation.

The prayer teaches us something easily forgotten: God has not abandoned His people simply because we cannot yet see what He is doing.

Sometimes faith is lived in the space between promise and fulfillment.

We wait.

We wonder.

We become tired.

And yet God remains faithful.

God Remembers

Zechariah remembers the promises made to Abraham and the covenant God made with His people.

This is not merely remembering history.

It is remembering who God is.

The God who made the promise is still God.

The God who was faithful to Abraham is faithful now.

The God who worked through generations is still working through ours.

We often measure God's presence by what is happening in front of us.

The Benedictus invites us to measure it differently.

Look back.

Remember.

God has been faithful before.

God has carried His people before.

God has brought light into darkness before.

And therefore, we can trust Him again.

Then Zechariah turns toward his son.

John will not be the light.

He will prepare the way for the Light.

His vocation is not to draw attention to himself, but to point beyond himself toward Christ.

There is something deeply Christian in this.

Our lives are not ultimately about making ourselves important.

We are called to prepare the way.

Perhaps that means preparing a way for Christ in our own hearts.

Perhaps it means preparing a way for Him in our families.

Perhaps it means becoming a little more patient, forgiving, truthful, merciful, and courageous so that another person may encounter something of God's love through us.

John prepares the way.

And so can we.

One of the most beautiful moments in the Benedictus comes near its end.

The coming of salvation is described through the tender mercy of God.

God does not save from a distance.

He draws near.

He visits His people.
He comes into our darkness.
And the image that follows is one of dawn.
The darkness does not overcome the light.
The light comes.
Slowly, perhaps.
Quietly, perhaps.
But it comes.

There are seasons when our own lives can feel like darkness.
We may not know what lies ahead.
We may carry grief, disappointment, fear, temptation, failure, or simply the exhaustion of ordinary life.
The Benedictus does not pretend that darkness does not exist.
Instead, it tells us where to look:
toward the dawn.

The final words of the Benedictus are not about giving us a complete map of the future.

They ask for something simpler:
that God may guide our feet into the way of peace.
Not necessarily the whole road.
Just the next step.
That may be all we need.

We do not always need to know where the road will eventually lead.
We need only enough light to take the next faithful step.

The Benedictus therefore becomes a prayer for our own lives.

When we are uncertain:
Guide our feet.

When we are afraid:
Guide our feet.

When we have wandered:
Guide our feet.

When we cannot see beyond the darkness:
Guide our feet into the way of peace.

And perhaps this is why the Church gives this canticle to the morning.
The day is beginning.
We do not know what it will bring.
But the dawn has come.

Christ is our light.
And we place our feet upon the road.
When you pray the Benedictus, do not rush through it.
Remember what God has done.
Remember His promises.
Remember that His mercy is still reaching toward you.
Bring before Him the darkness you carry.
Bring Him the people you love.
Bring Him the things you cannot control.
And then ask simply:
Lord, guide my feet today.
Not tomorrow.
Not through the whole of my life. Today.
Guide my feet into the way of peace.